

Careers and Career Goals

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D596: The Data Analytics Journey

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September 15, 2025

Self-Reflection

After completing the CliftonStrengths Assessment, my top five strengths were identified as Relator, Futuristic, Maximizer, Positivity, and Focus. These strengths reflect how I approach relationships, goals, and challenges in both personal and professional settings.

Relator

As a Relator, I value deep, meaningful connections. In my relationships, I tend to have a smaller circle of friends and am very close to my family. My best friend and I have been friends since we were 11, and now that we are 29, we are still very close. While I am not opposed to meeting new people, I hold friendships very close to me because I think they are very intimate. In friendships, you share so much of yourself, your goals, dreams, and secrets, and I think it is imperative to be friends with genuine and trustworthy people.

Futuristic

I consider myself realistic, but I also think the sky is the limit when thinking about your life. My Futuristic strength allows me to envision possibilities and set ambitious goals. I believe that since you cannot change the past, what you do in the present significantly affects your future.

Enrolling in school again has made me realize I have bigger dreams than I initially thought.

Enrolling in another master's program after I graduate and eventually becoming a Data Architect are things I never considered; however, working in the present has made me think about the future even more.

Maximizer

Being a Maximizer helps me realize that I always aim for excellence in everything I do, as it gratifies me. I spend my time working on my strengths, making them even stronger. While I recognize that working on your weaknesses is important too, I think if you focus too much on those, you may not see what other areas you excel in.

Positivity

Remaining positive is a core part of how I navigate the world. I always try to have a positive attitude and spread positivity, as things could be worse. My friends and family say that I always smile, and that is true even when things around me are chaotic. I've learned that remaining positive has helped me in many different scenarios.

Focus

Finally, my strength in remaining focused helps me stay on a path to fulfill my goals. I am self-driven, and being able to focus is needed to stay on track. Currently, my focus is on work and school. In this program, you must be able to focus on understanding and retaining the material.

Roles in Data Analytics

Data Analytics Teams can comprise several roles, including Data Analyst, Data Scientist, Data Architect, and Data Engineer. Each role helps organizations achieve goals through projects and thorough analysis. When looking at a career in data, it is important to know what each role entails and how your personal strengths can be an asset.

Data Engineer

Poulson (2022) defines the roles of a Data Engineer as people who focus on the hardware and the software that make data science possible; they provide the foundation for all other analyses. Data Scientists are often celebrated as "the high-flying flight pilots of big data," yet their success depends on the foundational work of data engineers, who "prepare the data that enables the data scientist to carry out organizational goals" (Oram, 2020, p. 1). According to Western Governors University (n.d), Data Engineers must have a strong educational background, usually in computer science, software engineering, information technology, or a related field. Aspiring Engineers should also familiarize themselves with programming languages like SQL, Python,

and Java. Data Engineers support the Data Analytics Life Cycle by providing the foundation of the cycle. By designing and building the framework for data collection, Data Acquisition is one of the most significant ways Data Engineers can support the life cycle.

Data Scientist

Western Governors University (2020) defines the role of a Data Scientist as professional who uses statistical, machine learning, and programming skills to analyze and interpret complex datasets and to develop and deploy predictive models and algorithms that can be used to solve business problems. Data Scientists use the dashboards created by Data Engineers to extract and analyze future trends and data. They extract insights, develop models and visualizations to guide stakeholders' decisions within an organization. Python, SQL and R, are programming languages Data Scientists typically use. Like their counterparts, Data Scientists also typically possess a degree in Computer Science, statistics, or even engineering. In the Data Analytics Life Cycle, Data Scientists support many phases including Data Cleaning, Predictive Modeling, and Data Mining. Data Scientist uses Data Cleaning to make sure the data doesn't have duplicates or is missing data. Predictive Modeling is used to create models that project future trends. Lastly, Data Mining is used to identify/detect patterns.

Data Analyst

Western Governors University (2020), states Data analysts' responsibilities are to collect, analyze, and interpret datasets. Depending on the industry, data analysts hold various responsibilities within organizations, such as collecting data; cleaning, preparing, and processing data; analyzing data; reporting and visualizing data; implementing predictive analysis; identifying data-driven decisions; and engaging in continuous improvement. While Data Scientists focus on future data and trends, Data Analysts focus on present data and trends. Data

Analysts typically need to know programs like Excel, SQL, and Python. Academics can vary, like Data Scientists and Engineers, Computer Science degrees are accepted, as well as degrees in Data Analytics or Business. Data Acquisition, Data Cleaning, and Reporting and Visualization are all phases in the Data Analytics Life Cycle the Data Analyst supports. Data acquisition is used to gather data, in this role the data could be extracted from SQL or Excel. The analyst would then clean the data; this could also take place in SQL or Excel. Lastly, Reporting and Visualization is used by the analyst to tell a story with the data, programs like Tableau or Power BI can be used to create visualizations.

Potential Career Goal

My career plan has altered since entering my master's program. Originally my long-term goal was to become a Data Scientist, since being in this course my goal is to become a Data Engineer while my shorter-term goal is to become a Data Scientist. I am currently a Data Analyst so I understand what is needed and how I can achieve my goals. My academic goals are to graduate from my current program and go back again to obtain a Masters in AI and Machine Learning. I could also see myself going back for my PhD in Data Analytics or AI and Machine Learning, eventually. Based on my strengths from my CliftonStrengths assessment, I think I possess the drive and focus to be able obtain my future goals.

Relator

Having Relator as a strength will help me with my goals because of my relationships. My family and friends are supportive of my aspirations, and they push me to continue being the best version of me I can be. Since enrolling in school, my friends understand that I may not be able to attend all events because I must study or write a paper, they are supportive in knowing I have a larger goal

to reach. It is important to me that Relator is a strength because I value the support of those, I hold relationships with.

Futuristic

Focusing on the future is essential while working to achieve my goal to become a Data Engineer. I constantly work to ensure my current academic and career endeavors are helping to achieve my long-term goals. I believe everyone can change their future, with the right resources. Thinking about my future excites me, I am excited to see where I will be in a year from now.

Maximizer

Striving for excellence is something I strive for in a facets of my life. Working to become a Data Engineer, this strength will help me because I will work my hardest to become an expert in programming languages like SQL and Python. I will also work to make sure dashboards and models are accurate. I take pride in my work and want to put my best foot forward every time I submit a project, reporting, etc.

Positivity

I tend to see the glass half full as opposed to empty. Being positive will help me reach my goal of becoming a Data Engineer because I also think of the bigger picture, and it makes me happy. I am always encouraging my teammates to chase their dreams and to be confident in themselves. There have been times where I may not feel 100% but I do try to find the good in most things, especially when it comes to my goals.

Focus

Focus being in my top 5 is very important in any career goal, but especially in the data analytics field. As a Data Analyst I constantly look for key details that the average person may not catch. Since Data Engineers lay the foundation, I will have to block out any distractions and

focus on the task at hand. For example, focusing in meetings with stakeholders, so that I can understand their needs before building pipelines.

Conclusion

The CliftonStrengths Assessment caused me to stop and do some self-reflection. Am I striving to be the best person I can be? Am I working hard enough to achieve my goals? I am constantly thinking about my goals and this assignment made me realize that I am on the right track. My goals and dreams are not a race, and I don't have to rush to reach them, just remain focused and consistent. I am excited to reach my goal of becoming a Data Engineer and I can't wait to come back to read this paper once I achieve my goal!

References

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(Western Governors University, 2020)